On November 19th, 1931, before the Federal Structure Committee, the Mahatma opposed the resolution on commercial safeguards for Britishers passed by the first Round Table Conference as being detrimental to the interests of the Indian people. He agreed that there should be no racial discrimination against foreigners as such. He also agreed that 'no existing interest legitimately acquired and not being in conflict with the best interests of the nation in general, shall be interfered with except in accordance with the law applicable to such interests'. But he made it clear that the National Government of the future might find it necessary to dispossess the 'haves' in the interests of the 'have-nots', i.e. the famished millions of India. Existing interests should be subjected to judicial scrutiny when necessary—but no racial question would be involved therein. He further opposed the existing rights[1] of the European community in India in regard to criminal trials. In his next speech at the Round Table Conference on November 25th, he maintained that the obligations to be taken over by the future National Government of India should be subject to audit and impartial examination.[2] He condemned the fixing of the currency ratio at 1s. 6d. instead of at 1s. 4d., as the Indian people had demanded. Continuing, he said : 'I would want complete control of the Indian finance if India was really to have responsibility at the centre. In my opinion, unless we have control over our own purse, absolutely unrestricted, we shall not be able to shoulder the responsibility nor will it be a responsibility worth the name.' In another speech, the same day, he maintained that after mature consideration he had come to the conclusion that provincial autonomy and central responsibility must go together. 'A strong centre governed and administered by an alien authority and a strong autonomy (for the provinces) are a contradiction in terms.' Speaking of central responsibility, he said : 'I want that responsibility at the centre that will give me, as you all know, control of the army and finance. I know that I am not going to get that here and now and I know there is not a British man ready for that. Therefore, I know I must go back and yet invite the nation to a course of suffering.'

Mahatma Gandhi's first speech at the plenary session of the

[1] For instance the right to have a European judge or a European jury in the trial

[2] In this connection he referred to the Report of the Public Debt Enquiry Committee appointed by the Karachi Congress in 1931.